responsible thereafter for executing the request.

2.3 Understanding middleware

Wow. That was a lot of abstract terms! Endpoint, middleware, pipeline ... but what do they actually mean? What do they represent? In the next section, we will explore them in more detail.

NOTE ASP.NET Core middleware is quite a large topic. I will only cover the areas that are likely to be of use in the majority of Razor Pages applications. If you would like to explore more advanced middleware concepts, such as branching the pipeline, I recommend *ASP.NET Core in Action, Second Edition*, by Andrew Lock (Manning, 2021).

First, given that the purpose of a Razor Pages application is to provide responses to HTTP requests, it is appropriate to review and understand the nature of an HTTP request and how it is represented within a Razor Pages application. That will form the basis of your understanding of pipelines and endpoints.

2.3.1 An HTTP refresher

Hypertext Transfer Protocol (HTTP) is the foundation for the World Wide Web. It is a protocol for transferring information between systems in the client-server model. An HTTP transaction can be seen as consisting of two basic elements: a request and a response. The *request* is the input, and the *response* is the output. Clients initiate requests, and servers provide responses, as figure 2.11 demonstrates.